
Volume Forecast: What 11 Years of Enquiry Data Tells Us

Prepared for: Gurmej Pawar, Jess Harrar **Date:** 8 May 2026 **Source:** Live MySQL archive (read-only)

The Scaling document left one question open: Gurmej's "annual +10%" or Jess's "skyrockets June/July"? Neither. We pulled every enquiry on file (four MySQL tables, 2015 to 2025). The pattern is sharper than either guess.

Summary

Peak month is **September, every year, by a wide margin**. Same curve annually: slow first half, ramp from June, sharp September spike, fast tail to year-end.

Both 22 April growth views were half right. Annual totals are roughly flat (closer to Gurmej's "not wildly different" than +10%). Jess's ramp is real but lands **August to October**, not June to July.

Scaling impact: size the deliverability cliffs against the September peak (**20 to 25 enquiries per day for weeks**), not a flat year-round average.

The Headline Finding

Every year for at least a decade, intake peaks in the same 7-week window: August through mid-October. Eight of nine complete seasons peaked in September. The exception (2018) peaked in October.

Not a 2025 fluke. Visible in every year back to 2015. Consistent enough to plan against directly: treat August to October as a different operating regime from the other nine months.

Biggest day on record: **3 September 2025**, 42 enquiries in 24 hours. Every runner-up day is also September (15th, 16th, 22nd 2025; 25 Sep 2024; 18 Sep 2019).

The 2025 Curve, Month by Month

2025, the most recent complete season: 2,762 enquiries, distributed like this.

Month	Enquiries	Month	Enquiries
Jan	2	Jul	497
Feb	5	Aug	519
Mar	5	Sep	712
Apr	14	Oct	459
May	71	Nov	263
Jun	199	Dec	16

2025 monthly enquiry counts ($n = 2,762$)

September alone: **712 enquiries**, more than January to June combined (296). August to October (1,690) was **61% of the year** in 25% of the calendar.

Same Shape Every Year

If 2025 were anomalous, 2024 would look different. It doesn't (3,095 enquiries):

Month	Enquiries	Month	Enquiries
Jan	9	Jul	398
Feb	13	Aug	438
Mar	25	Sep	537
Apr	76	Oct	469
May	349	Nov	330
Jun	415	Dec	36

2024 monthly enquiry counts ($n = 3,095$)

Same curve. Peak still September. 2024's spring ramp is steeper from a stronger early-year intake, but September is the highest point both years.

Peak months further back:

Year	Peak month	Enquiries
2015	September	243
2016	September	156
2017	September	92
2018	October	136
2019	September	183
2023	September	372
2024	September	537
2025	September	712

Eight of nine complete seasons peak in September. The exception (2018) peaks in October by a small margin.

A Decade in Totals

Pre-COVID: roughly 600 to 800 enquiries a year. 2020 to 2022 is missing from every archive table (COVID collapse plus an archive that doesn't span those years). Post-pandemic: roughly 4x the volume.

Year	Total	Note
2015	865	May start
2016	647	
2017	227	sparse data
2018	594	
2019	665	
2020 to 2022	n/a	data gap
2023	1,927	Mar start
2024	3,095	
2025	2,762	

- 2024 to 2025 declined about 11% (3,095 to 2,762). Closer to Gurmej's "not wildly different" than +10% growth.
- 2026 year-to-date (through 7 May): 181 enquiries. Well within the post-2022 regime, not a regression to the pre-COVID baseline.
- The 2017 total (227) is almost certainly a data gap, not a quiet year. Years either side look normal.

What This Means For The Scaling Decision

The Scaling document mapped three deliverability cliffs against a flat ~30 outbound emails per day. That average is misleading. Size the cliffs against the September peak, not the mean.

A typical September day: **20 to 25 enquiries**, sustained for weeks. At 4 to 6 emails per enquiry, that's **100 to 150 outbound per day from the single mailbox** through September, plus catch-up sends from late-August enquiries still in their follow-up window.

Revised exposure to each cliff:

Cliff	Exposure
Cliff 1 (Soft)	30-per-day baseline to 100 to 150 per day in September is roughly a 3 to 5 times jump. Squarely inside Gmail's spam-filter heuristics on volume spikes. Realistic risk this September.
Cliff 2 (Hard)	The 2,000-per-day Workspace cap stays well clear at 100 to 150 sustained. Only a risk if a single day produced more than ~400 enquiries, which the data says is very unlikely (all-time single-day peak was 42).
Cliff 3 (Regulatory)	The 5,000-per-day bulk-sender threshold is far off. No realistic September scenario for the Christmas-side flow brings it close. (The Instantly outbound side is separate.)

Translation: **Path A (monitor and stay) is genuinely at risk this September.** Path B (multi-mailbox) holds: spread the September load across 2 to 3 mailboxes and each stays under the cliff. Path C is right if the Instantly outbound work moves forward and you want shared infrastructure.

How We Got This Data

Pulled directly from the live database, not a survey or estimate:

1. Read-only MySQL via the existing automation connection (UTIL scenario 8974201, no separate credentials).
2. Data split across four tables: `enquiries` (live, 181 rows), `all_enquiries` (2015 to 2020, 3,005 rows), `full_data_enquiries` (2023 to 2026, 7,833 rows), `enquiries_backup_23-04-2025` (April 2025 snapshot, 3,859 rows).
3. Reconciled by date range, schema discovery, de-duplication. The 2020 to 2022 stretch sits in none of the four tables.
4. All aggregation in SQL against the live tables. Nothing extracted, exported, or persisted outside the database.

Caveats and Confidence

- **The 2020 to 2022 gap is real.** The COVID-era curve is unknown. Pre- and post-COVID patterns are consistent enough to trust the September-peak framing, but a lockdown-driven behaviour shift would not be visible here.
- **full_data_enquiries is stale for 2026.** It shows 49 rows for 2026; the live table has 181 through 7 May. Late-April and early-May 2026 daily counts may be slightly undercounted in any historical aggregate.
- **The 2017 total (227) is suspicious.** Other archive years are 600-plus. Likely a partial-year data issue, not a real drop.
- **Single-day peak (42) is 2025-09-03.** A higher day could exist in the 2020 to 2022 gap. Treat 42 as a lower bound.
- **"Enquiry" = a database row,** from website form, phone capture, or referral feed. Not separated by source; per-source breakdown is a follow-up query.

If any caveat matters for the path decision, say so and we'll dig further before locking a recommendation.